

Your craziest job interview stories: 'The chair flew up and knocked out my teeth'

From the Guardian.

Our readers share their wildest job interview disasters.

In our recent GuardianWitness assignment, we asked you for your quirkiest job interview stories. From turning up to an interview dressed as Bart Simpson to knocking out two front teeth, here's a collection of our readers' wildest interview blunders.

A leading fashion designer said I had 'the wrong star sign'

I was a fresh design graduate and had had two interviews already at a leading fashion designer. Their business partner loved my portfolio, so I thought I had the job. Third interview was with the designer's husband, who came in the room and asked one question: "What's your star sign?" After hearing my reply he turned around and walked straight out. I was stunned, turned to the business partner and asked what went wrong. He shook his head and said: "Same as his wife. He won't have anyone who shares her star sign." And that was that. – **PaleLucas**

'The chair flew up and knocked out my front teeth. There was blood everywhere'

I was offered a job interview for an IT company and passed the first interview well, then had an informal second interview with my potential line manager, which went even better. They asked me to take lunch with a secretary at a top restaurant – which went really well – while they discussed my application with the chief executive.

I got back from lunch nervous, but also feeling confident. "The chief executive will see you in ten minutes." I got my paperwork in order, combed my hair, flossed. I was on fire. I walked into the chief executive's office. "Great to see you." I pulled up a chair but released the height mechanism by accident. The chair flew up and hit me in the mouth, knocking out my two front teeth. There was blood everywhere.

The chat with the chief executive actually went well (after a short break for repairs) but when they offered me the job it was on a terrible salary and I think my first impression cost me a lot. – [1scamp](#)

'I slid over the newly surfaced floor and landed in a puddle'

I had an interview at my dream school a few years ago. I arrived early, just as it began to pour with rain, and by the time I'd crossed the car park I was drenched. The deputy head met me and the other candidates just as I was beginning to dry off and took us on a tour around the school. The tour began with me sliding over on the newly resurfaced floor in the main hall – landing on my hands and knees in a puddle. Needless to say, I didn't get the job.

My interviewer said: 'I knew you were the right person, even if you were 24 hours late'

I received an invitation to attend an interview for a role I really wanted for the following Wednesday. However, on the Tuesday I received a phone call asking if I was coming to the interview. I said, "Yes, I am coming tomorrow." The person calling said the interview was that day. I had got the date wrong. Luckily, I was invited to attend an interview the next day and walked into the interview saying: "I have been five minutes late, half an hour late but never 24 hours late." All my answers were totally honest as I did not think I had much of a chance. I was offered the job. Three years later I was at an awards ceremony receiving an accolade for our innovative work with young people. The person who had interviewed me leaned over and said: "I knew that you were the right person for this role, even if you were late." – junks

'Help! They're towing away my car'

I went for a job interview at a large company in North London. I arrived on time, parked my car, did some last minute prep, and went in confidently to the interview. The interviewer's office overlooked the car park and half way through I suddenly saw a tow truck taking my car away. What do I do? In hindsight I should have kept my mouth shut, but at the time I was in utter shock. So I told the interviewer that my car was being towed away, and looked at her for some sympathy. I expected her to suggest we suspend the interview. Her response? Cold as ice. "Well, there's nothing much you can do about it now, so let's continue." I can't really remember much after that but I knew I wasn't getting the job, and even if I did, I didn't want to work with someone that ruthless.

Are you a snail or a whale?

I went for a job interview at a primary school some years ago. The final, quirky question from the governors was: "What is your favourite children's book, and why?" I answered that it was *The Snail and the Whale* by Julia Donaldson (Gruffalo author), because it was about helping each other and that everyone has a strength regardless of appearance, which I felt was a positive message to send children. The governor then asked me: "So are you a snail or a whale?" Being quite a cuddly woman, I didn't really want to answer what seemed like a disrespectful question! It was OK in the end though. We had a good laugh about it and I got the job.

'I was dressed as Bart Simpson and, surprisingly, got the job'

I was called up by a recruiter and asked if I could go to an interview on the same day, while roaming the streets of London dressed as Bart Simpson. Surprisingly, I got the job – along with some interesting looks in the waiting room

Reading Comprehension Activities

Activity 1: True, False, or Not Given (T/F/NG)

Read the following statements. Decide if the statement is **True (T)**, **False (F)**, or **Not Given (NG)** in the text. For a statement to be True, all parts of it must be explicitly confirmed or clearly inferable from the text.

1. The fresh design graduate was rejected by the business partner after the third interview. **T**
2. The chief executive of the IT company suggested taking a brief pause for repairs after the interviewee's dental injury. **T**
3. The interviewee who was 24 hours late was originally invited via a written letter to attend the interview. **NG**
4. The interviewer who saw the car being towed was entirely unsympathetic and proceeded with the interview as if nothing had happened. **T**
5. The woman dressed as Bart Simpson was a professional actor taking a break when she got the call from the recruiter. **NG**
6. The interviewee who slipped on the newly surfaced floor initially arrived early while it was raining heavily. **T**
7. The "Snail or Whale" interviewee ultimately secured the primary school job primarily because she gave a well-thought-out answer about the book's positive message. **NG**

The following phrasal verbs were found in the article about job interview stories:

1. **Turn up**
2. **Turned around**
3. **Walked out**
4. **Shook his head**
5. **Looked at**
6. **Keep my mouth shut**
7. **Leaned over**
8. **Called up**
9. **Pulled up**
10. **Towing away**

Complete the sentences below using the correct form of one of the phrasal verbs from the list above. You may need to change the tense or form (e.g., past simple, gerund, etc.).

1. After being told he had the wrong star sign, the designer's husband simply shook his head. and walked out of the room immediately.
2. The interviewee regretted not having had his mouth shut when the tow truck started towing away his car.
3. The secretary and the candidate went to a top restaurant while the managers discussed the application, which turned around "really well".
4. The successful candidate for the school job turned up to the interview dressed as Bart Simpson, which was quite a sight for the waiting room.
5. At the awards ceremony, the interviewer leaned over and admitted that she had known the candidate was the right person all along.
6. Upon entering the chief executive's office, the candidate pulled up a chair, accidentally releasing the height mechanism.
7. The business partner shook his head sadly when explaining the designer's irrational reason for the rejection.